FERN LOOP NATURE TRAIL

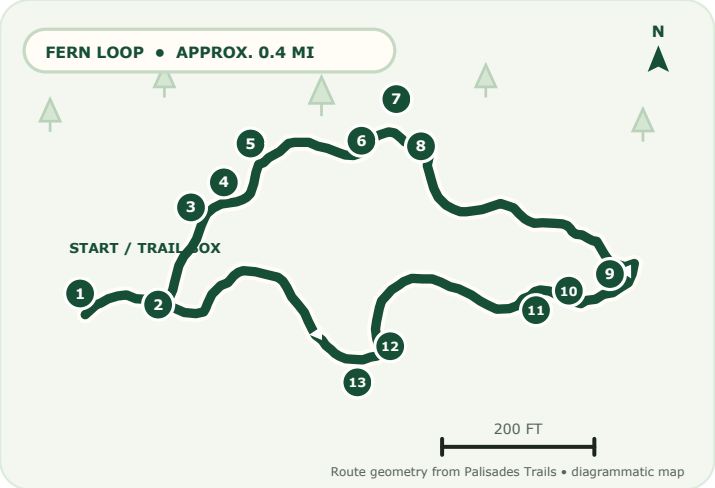
SELF-GUIDED WALK

Follow the numbered markers from 1 through 13. Each marker corresponds to a description below; look all around it for the plants and features described. Flowers, fruit, cones, and fern spores are seasonal. **Enjoy your walk.**

1 Floodplain / Brandywine

Fern Loop follows the floodplain of the four-mile Brandywine. The creek's copper color comes from tannins released by decaying oak leaves. Look for Bracken Fern, thorny Greenbrier, True Solomon's-seal, and Canada Mayflower.

Behind the trail box, a large Beech has smooth gray bark and exposed roots like elephant feet. A mature Tulip Poplar stands on the creek bank. West of the bridge is a Hemlock cluster with small cones and flat, dark green needles striped white underneath. Head upstream toward Waypoint 2.



2 Fern Loop Entrance / Sassafras

At the Fern Loop entrance, the trail sign is attached to a Sassafras snag. Fallen trees in the stream slow the current, stabilize the banks, and shelter fish. Along the trail, compare invasive Barberry's small pear-shaped leaves and red fall berries with the soft, velvety leaves of native Mapleleaf Viburnum.

Nearby Witch-hazel has scalloped, lopsided leaves. Look for a Red Maple with a yellow blaze and a native Grape Vine climbing toward the sun on a snag to the north.

3 White Pine / Oaks

A very large White Pine has fallen here. Decaying trees provide wildlife habitat, return nutrients to the soil, and become nurse logs. At right, a large Red Oak shows gray vertical 'ski tracks' on its bark. You may find lightweight, ping-pong-ball-sized insect galls below it.

Red Oak leaves have pointed, shiny lobes; White Oak leaves have rounded, duller lobes. Look also for American Cancer-root near the oaks, Witch-hazel to the left, and young Beeches with papery leaves and parallel veins.

4 Oxbow

The curved depression is an old oxbow wetland, formed when the stream changed course. It holds water and helps reduce flooding during heavy rain. Look for large Royal Ferns and snags with big, squarish holes excavated by Pileated Woodpeckers. Other birds and mammals later use these cavities.

5 Beech - Maple Woods / Climax Forest

This is a Beech-Maple woods, one of southwest Michigan's two dominant woodland ecosystems; the other is Oak-Hickory. Look north toward the dune hill and its column-like Red Oaks. Scattered White Pines add one new tier of branches each year, revealing their annual growth.

A huge Red Oak with a yellow blaze stands just behind you. Walk between two large oaks toward Waypoint 6, and look high into the canopy for their pointed-lobed leaves.

6 Sassafras

Just beyond the marker is a large Sassafras with reddish-brown, deeply furrowed bark and a natural split about 35 feet up. Its leaves appear in four 'mitten' shapes: two-thumbed, left-thumbed, right-thumbed, and without a thumb.

Sassafras turns brilliant orange in fall, spreads through underground stems, and hosts several Swallowtail butterflies and the Promethea Moth.

7 Tulip Trees (Yellow Poplar)

A stand of Tulip Trees, also called Yellow Poplars, grows from the giant tree at your right. Often the forest's tallest tree, it has a straight trunk, evenly furrowed bark, tulip-profile leaves, and orange-and-yellow spring flowers.

This is Michigan's only native member of the Magnolia family and a host for the Eastern Tiger Swallowtail and Tuliptree Silkmoth. Partridgeberry is the evergreen ground plant here.

8 Hemlock / Red Maple

Here is a medium-sized Hemlock near the southern edge of the tree's range. Climate warming and the invasive, sap-sucking Hemlock Woolly Adelgid both threaten these trees. Water Hemlock is a different, highly poisonous wetland plant; none grows on this trail.

On the right, note the three-trunked Red Maple. Its leaves are saw-toothed, unlike Sugar Maple leaves. Witch-hazel forms a shrub canopy over the trail toward Waypoint 9.

9 Creek / Stream

From spring through fall, look for woodland mushrooms that feed deer, small mammals, insects, Box Turtles, and Wild Turkeys. Mapleleaf Viburnum berries along the banks feed many birds and mammals. Stop and listen for a Red-eyed Vireo or Acadian Flycatcher, and watch the stream for a Great Blue Heron.

10 Sassafras / Wood Sedge

Sassafras is plentiful here. Large trees have familiar furrowed bark; small ones show bright green twigs. Rub a leaf and twig to release the scent of Sassafras tea.

A Red Maple stands above and left of the marker. At its base are clumps of grassy-looking Wood Sedge. Sedges differ from grasses by their solid, triangular stems: 'sedges have edges.'

11 Poison Ivy / Sugar Maple

Learn Poison Ivy early. A small plant grows at the base of this marker. It has three leaflets without sawteeth; look for a notch just behind the tip on one side. Touching it - or breathing particles from mowing or burning it - can cause a blistering reaction. After contact, wash promptly with strong soap or detergent.

Toward the Brandywine is a large Sugar Maple. Its five-lobed leaves have smooth edges. Older trunks develop flat bark plates, and paired winged seeds form a horseshoe shape. Fine Pennsylvania Sedge grows along the path.

12 Basswood / Virginia Creeper

Across the stream to the left, look for an American Basswood; yellowish-white summer flowers and their leaflike bracts aid identification. Virginia Creeper has five saw-toothed leaflets, not Poison Ivy's three, and turns brilliant red in autumn.

Toward the next marker, crush a Northern Spicebush leaf to release its fragrance. Female shrubs bear red fall berries; tiny yellow flowers appear in early spring. Spicebush hosts the Spicebush Swallowtail.

13 Hog-peanut / Small White Pines

American Hog-peanut, or Ground Bean, is abundant here. This native legume has three leaflets and produces flowers both above and below ground. Small mammals and ground birds eat its seeds; it also hosts the Silver-spotted Skipper and Northern Cloudywing.

Nearby White Pines have five needles per cluster - an easy identification mark. Continue along the Brandywine bank trail toward the bridge.